Views From East 1st to Marble Hill

Before Dawn – 6:00am

A young man stands in front of the mirror of his unheated bathroom. Sleepy eyed, he stares through the glass, toothbrush hovering. For a while he is unable to recognize his own face, only the outline of his body can he identify. He brushes his teeth but forgets the toothpaste.

Dawn – 7:00am

A family shares breakfast at the same table, but eats in separate rooms.

Morning – 8:45am

An old man sits perfectly still on the subway. He has on a black hat, a loosely fitted jacket overtop a smartly striped button-down which he has tucked into his pants, and squeezed between his knees a heavy leather-bound briefcase – all items the kind of which are not made like they used to. The subway car jostles him, tries to startle him with unpredictable sounds of metal-on-metal, casts shadows upon his face. It goads the children to snicker at him, and, were he to ever to turn around, would make them avert their gaze so far away as to only be directed at him. The old man, for his part, simply coughs once and looks on. What does he see, looking so intently ahead? Perhaps he imagines he is in the belly of a great worm, thin translucent panes beaten into its skin, outside of which contains the secrets of a foreign land.

Morning – 9:30am

A little girl, walking to school, one hand in her father's and the other on a street-vended hotdog, drops the bun down a sidewalk grate to see where it goes.

Morning – 11:00am

A construction worker lies backwards on a support beam, lifts his shirt, and drinks in the perfect blue sky with his exposed belly. He dreams that he is flying, accompanying the single cloud above. His body spreadeagle, he soars higher with every flap of his arms. The hammers and clangs of construction are the birdsong of gulls and the sound of distant thunder.

Morning – 11:30am

Employees at the water cooler, who cool themselves with gossip like gazelles at a watering hole, scatter when they see their boss approaching.

Noon – 11:50am to 12:30pm

Today is the parade! The parade for what (or more appropriately, for 'whom,' if you are in the know) you ask? Why, it is the parade for Thomas, of course! All around the city, street sweeps and housing committees have been putting up streamers since before dawn. The road has been cleared from his home on 34th all the way down to Madison Avenue to make way for the floats. Some kids are let out of school early. The precinct has tasked only their finest and most affable cops to oversee the processions, and they laugh and smile and pin plastic badges upon the chests

of children. Hawkers unfurl their blankets and place upon them all sorts of commemorative knick-knacks. One such hawker is engaged in heated argument with a group of Japanese tourists after attempting to set up shop beneath their feet; they, who had flown in this morning with the express purpose of coalescing underneath this convenience store, brandishing their digital cameras and extendable photo-sticks, ready to eternalize the occasion. And look, here he comes! The parade float is capacious – it has room for every color fit for a party. A flurry of cheers escorts the float, passing down the busy streets like a relay baton. Thomas stands, head bowed in gratitude, but unbent by misplaced flattery. He is wearing a sweater the color of golden October, a choice which the announcers agree really brings out his eyes. Crowds press against the barricades trying to get closer.

Suddenly, the assembled mass discovers a weak-spot, and the cops are helpless as throngs of fans surround the float. They grab its flowing tassels; a sea of bodies, they reach out with loving arms towards the object of their affection. Several people try to climb atop the float but are quickly pushed off by the security detail back onto the mass below. Thomas smiles bashfully at the crowd, bends down on one knee and touches his followers on their hands and foreheads. Limbs, the pressure of body-on-body, ecstatic shouts which punctuate the percussion of the marching band. In one corner of the festivity, unseen to all, a woman is crushed underneath the wheel of the parade float, only to be discovered much later.

Noon – 12:50

A man sits at a baseball game and is hungry. He feels a thousand eyes from rows and rows boring into the back of his head.

Lunch Rush – 1:00pm

The offices are let out for 30 minutes of lunch. The boss turns a kitchen timer.

Midday – 1:10pm

Having waited long enough, the customers at the local deli are now furious. Packed in like sardines, they repurpose kitchen-ware and three-legged stools and descend vengefully upon the woefully outnumbered employees manning the counter, determined to make their own lunch.

Midday – 1:15pm

Among the bustle of 34 and 3rd, a woman closes her eyes and sees for the first time an empty street.

Midday – 1:25pm

A man collapses in the middle of a crowd. Pressing in, they all try CPR.

Midday – 1:30pm

The kitchen timer goes off.

Midday – 1:30pm

The hotdog is still falling.

Afternoon – 2:00pm

Having improperly brushed his teeth this morning, the office-worker took lunch at his desk, where he subsequently fell asleep. Bleary-brained, he lifts his head up from his cubicle into the grid of unearthly fluorescent lamps, and finds above him the brilliance of heaven. He files paperwork underneath the firmament. Out the window, and across the street, in a tower larger than all the rest, throughout every floor of its stratified architecture, and in every room within each floor, lies the Great Chain of Being.

Afternoon – 3:32pm

A student stares lazily out the window of fourth period math, and guesses, with perfect accuracy, what the world will look like in 15 years.

Afternoon – 4:15pm

Two conspiratorial siblings gnaw at the rope their parents have tied to them while they go grocery shopping.

Afternoon – 4:16pm

Cleanup in aisle 6.

Afternoon – 4:17pm

May the Vandenberger parents please come to the checkout in lane 3. We have your children, and will ransom them back once you have paid us their worth in damaged groceries.

Afternoon – 5:30pm

In the afternoons, the smell of grilled meats over charcoal perfumes the parks where old men play chess, and extended families come to lay blankets in the shade. It is times like these when your brain can feel like sunshine.

Evening – 6:30pm

As they step off the train, exhausted from a long day's work, people slough off the spindly arms of their chrysalis skins and greet their smiling children. As they come off, the skins make a snapping noise; the empty husks lie dormant on the platform like dead praying mantises, where they will be swept up by staff later in the night.

Evening – 7:45pm

A tankard of wine punctures. A bar floods. The merry drunks grab on to tables, chairs, each other, as they are taken away by their bacchanalian pleasures. En route, they continue to toast to their health.

Gloaming – 9:00pm

In the soft glow of twilight, a man, stabbed, falls into the arms of his assailant. Like lovers, he sinks syrupy into their burly frame, and watches as the alley lamps and window lights turn themselves on one by one, like the first night of fireflies in autumn.